

CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

SCENE 9 - "WHAT WILL HE BE?" / THE TOWN TURNS

COMPANY VERSION

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SCENE 9 — “WHAT WILL HE BE?” / THE TOWN TURNS

Approximate Running Time: 6 minutes

Musical Number: “What Will He Be?” — approximately 2–2½ minutes

Gossip Sequence: approximately 60–90 seconds

Characters:

Mary

Joseph

Shira

Talia

Adina

Dafna

Levi

Malachi

Caleb

Ezra

Nia

Simon

Children

Villagers

Roman Announcer

CONTINUOUS FROM SCENE 8

No traditional blackout.

Mary and Joseph are walking home together.

The familiar sound of Nazareth begins before the marketplace is fully visible.

HAMMER. BASKET. FABRIC SNAP. CLAP.

The same work vocabulary from Scene 1.

The same stalls. The same baskets. The same fabric. The same people.

For a breath, it feels like home.

Mary and Joseph enter at the edge of the marketplace, still holding hands.

One villager notices.

Then another.

A conversation slows.

A woman stops folding fabric.

A merchant looks up.

No one has become a villain. They simply know—or think they know.

Mary feels the change in the room before anyone says anything.

Her hand tightens around Joseph's.

Joseph answers with his own.

They keep walking.

THE CHILDREN BREAK THE TENSION

NIA

Mary!

Nia runs toward her before an adult can stop her.

Simon follows, more cautiously. Several children trail behind.

VILLAGER WOMAN 1

Nia—

Too late.

NIA

You're back!

MARY

I'm back.

Simon looks at Mary. Then Joseph. Then Mary again.

SIMON

Is it true?

VILLAGER WOMAN 2

Simon!

SIMON

What?

NIA

You cannot just ask people things like that.

SIMON

You were going to ask.

NIA

I was going to ask better.

Mary cannot help a small laugh.

MARY

It's all right.

NIA

Are you really having a baby?

Mary looks briefly at Joseph, then back to the children.

MARY

Yes.

The children light up immediately.

No scandal. No hesitation. Just a baby.

CHILD 1

A boy or a girl?

MARY

A boy.

CHILD 2

When is he coming?

SIMON

Babies do not tell you that.

NIA

How do you know?

SIMON

Everybody knows that.

NIA

You didn't even know where babies—

SIMON

Nia!

A few adults react. Mary covers another laugh. Joseph does too.

CHILD 3

What will he be like?

Mary pauses.

MARY

I don't know.

CHILD 3

You don't?

MARY

Not yet.

SIMON

Will he be loud?

NIA

All babies are loud.

CHILD 1

Maybe he'll like stories.

CHILD 2

Maybe he'll build things.

The child looks toward Joseph.

CHILD 2

Like you.

Joseph is caught off guard—not by the question, but by the future inside it.

JOSEPH

Maybe.

CHILD 3

Will you teach him?

Joseph looks at Mary.

This time he does not avoid the answer.

JOSEPH

If he wants to learn, I'll teach him.

SIMON

What if he's terrible at it?

JOSEPH

Then I'll teach him twice.

The children laugh.

A light musical pulse begins.

NIA

What do you think he'll be?

“WHAT WILL HE BE?” BEGINS

“WHAT WILL HE BE?” — MUSICAL TERRITORY

The children lead. Warm, playful, imaginative. The number is entirely about possibility.

The adults remain in the marketplace, some working, some watching, some whispering.

The song must not explain who Jesus becomes. The audience supplies that knowledge.

LYRICAL TERRITORY — NOT FINAL LYRICS:

Will he laugh too loud? / Will he sleep all day? / Will he race through every market stall / and leave his things in everybody's way?

Will he love stories? / Will he climb trees? / Will he ask a hundred questions / before anyone can breathe?

SIMON

A hundred?

NIA

You ask more than that.

The music continues.

The children imagine ordinary futures: animals, stories, running, helping, learning, teaching, courage, kindness.

CHILD 2

Will he build things out of wood?

JOSEPH

Maybe.

CHILD 3

Will you teach him everything?

Joseph looks at the child, then at Mary.

JOSEPH

Everything I know.

That line lands quietly.

The song grows more thoughtful without becoming prophetic.

Possible territory: Will he make somebody smile / when they've forgotten how? / Will he stand beside a friend / when everybody else walks out?

Will he be gentle? / Will he be brave? / Will he make a difference / in somebody's day?

NIA / CHILDREN

What will he be?

The audience knows more than the children do. That is where the emotion comes from.

THE SECOND QUESTION

As the children repeat the bright question, a second question begins underneath them.

CHILDREN

What will he be?

GOSSIPER 1

Whose child is it?

VILLAGER WOMAN 1

Before the wedding.

GOSSIPER 2

Joseph knows?

GOSSIPER 4

Claro que sabe. Of course, he knows.

CHILDREN

What will he be?

GOSSIPER 3

Then why is he still with her?

VILLAGER WOMAN 2

She says there was an angel.

GOSSIPER 4

¿Un ángel?

GOSSIPER 3

That's what I heard.

Villager 3 looks toward Mary.

GOSSIPER 4

Eso es lo que escuchaste.

Beat.

GOSSIPER 3

That's what you heard.

The children remain musically innocent.

Underneath them, the adults begin finding the old Scene 1 gossip rhythm.

Same machinery. Different consequence.

SONG ENDS

The children finish joyfully.

CHILDREN

What will he be?

A brief release—then an adult voice.

VILLAGER WOMAN 1

Nia. Come here.

NIA

But—

VILLAGER WOMAN 1

Now.

Another adult calls a child away.

CHILD 2

Why?

VILLAGER WOMAN 2

Come along.

One by one, the children are removed from Mary's orbit.

Mary watches a child who was laughing beside her moments ago get pulled away.

That hurts more than an insult.

SIMON

What happened?

No adult answers him.

THE GOSSIP RHYTHM RETURNS

A restrained fragment of "Welcome to Nazareth" lives underneath the dialogue, not celebratory now, but tight and repetitive.

GOSSIPER 1

Before the wedding—

GOSSIPER 2

That's what I heard.

GOSSIPER 3

Joseph knows.

GOSSIPER 4

Ay, everybody knows Joseph knows.

GOSSIPER 1

Then why—

GOSSIPER 2

Don't ask me.

GOSSIPER 4

They say she claims—

GOSSIPER 3

God.

A few villagers react.

GOSSIPER 2

God?

GOSSIPER 1

That's what she said.

GOSSIPER 4

Convenient.

In Scene 1, everybody knowing everybody was comedy.

Now everybody thinks they know enough.

MARY'S FRIENDS

Shira moves to Mary immediately.

SHIRA

You all right?

MARY

Yes.

She is not completely all right.

SHIRA

All right.

Shira stays.

Adina joins them, scanning the marketplace.

ADINA

This is getting worse.

DAFNA

That is not helpful.

ADINA

I'm not trying to be helpful. I'm trying to be accurate.

DAFNA

That's Talia's job.

Talia arrives.

TALIA

What is my job?

DAFNA

Being accurate.

TALIA

Then Adina is correct.

Dafna stares at her.

DAFNA

Nobody here understands comfort.

A small breath of humor. Then—

VILLAGER WOMAN 3

You believe her?

The question is aimed at Talia.

Talia does not pretend certainty she does not have.

TALIA

I believe Mary told us what happened to her.

VILLAGER WOMAN 3

That is not what I asked.

TALIA

I know.

VILLAGER WOMAN 3

So you don't believe it either.

TALIA

I didn't say that.

VILLAGER WOMAN 3

Then what are you saying?

Talia steps slightly closer to Mary.

TALIA

I'm saying you weren't there.

VILLAGER WOMAN 3

Neither were you.

Talia takes the point.

TALIA

No.

Beat.

TALIA

Which means neither of us gets to humiliate her over something we did not see.

Mary looks at her.

Talia gives the smallest nod.

She stays.

JOSEPH'S FRIENDS

Levi, Malachi, Caleb, and Ezra enter or emerge from the marketplace.

They see the crowd. Then Joseph. Then Mary holding Joseph's hand.

Levi stops.

LEVI

You're really doing this.

JOSEPH

Yes.

LEVI

After everything you told us?

JOSEPH

Yes.

LEVI

You believe her?

JOSEPH

I do.

Levi lowers his voice.

LEVI

Then help me understand.

JOSEPH

I can't.

Levi did not expect that.

JOSEPH

Not all of it.

Beat.

JOSEPH

But I know enough to know she told me the truth.

LEVI

I'm trying to protect you.

JOSEPH

I know.

LEVI

Then let me.

JOSEPH

This is me telling you what I chose.

Levi does not like it. But he hears him.

CALEB

You sure?

JOSEPH

I am.

Caleb nods and moves to Joseph's side.

EZRA

There are still several things about this that make absolutely no sense.

CALEB

Ezra.

EZRA

There are.

JOSEPH

I know.

EZRA

And you're comfortable with that?

Joseph almost smiles at the absurdity.

JOSEPH

No.

Ezra did not expect that either.

JOSEPH

But understanding everything and knowing what I need to do are not always the same thing.

Ezra considers it.

MALACHI

That's enough for today.

Malachi stands beside Joseph.

Ezra hesitates, then joins them.

Levi remains slightly apart.

THE PUBLIC TEST

A Villager Man steps forward. Not a villain. A neighbor who believes he is saying the obvious thing.

VILLAGER MAN

Joseph. You don't have to do this.

JOSEPH

Do what?

VILLAGER MAN

Carry another man's shame.

The marketplace quiets.

Mary stiffens.

Joseph remains controlled.

JOSEPH

You don't know what you're talking about.

VILLAGER MAN

Everybody knows what happened.

JOSEPH

No.

Beat.

JOSEPH

Everybody knows what they heard.

The Villager Man looks at him.

VILLAGER MAN

And you're willing to throw away your name for this?

Levi reacts to the language.

Joseph sees it.

JOSEPH

My name isn't worth much if I have to destroy hers to protect it.

Silence.

The Villager Man turns toward Mary.

VILLAGER MAN

Is what they're saying true?

Joseph does not step in front of Mary.

Mary steps forward herself.

MARY

I told the truth.

VILLAGER MAN

About an angel?

MARY

Yes.

Some villagers stare. A few whisper. One or two may laugh under their breath.

VILLAGER WOMAN 2

And you expect all of us to believe that?

Mary looks around at people she has known all her life.

MARY

No.

That surprises them.

MARY

I can't make you believe me.

Beat.

MARY

But I will not call what happened to me a lie just to make you comfortable.

Silence.

This is Mary's public choice.

JOSEPH TRIES TO FIX IT

The whispers restart.

GOSSIPER 2

Did you hear—

GOSSIPER 3

She admitted—

GOSSIPER 4

Joseph actually—

JOSEPH

Enough!

Mary gently touches his arm.

MARY

Joseph.

JOSEPH

They're talking about you.

MARY

I know.

JOSEPH

I can explain—

MARY

To all of them?

Joseph looks around.

Every face has an opinion.

MARY

You don't have to answer everyone.

JOSEPH

I want to.

MARY

I know.

Beat.

MARY

But you can't build your way out of this.

It lands without cruelty.

Joseph looks at the village.

For once, he lets the problem remain unsolved.

NIA AND SIMON

Nia and Simon have watched all of this from nearby.

NIA

Why is everybody angry?

No one answers.

SIMON

It's still a baby.

The simple line hangs there.

NIA

We were just singing.

An adult calls.

VILLAGER WOMAN 1

Nia.

Nia does not move immediately.

VILLAGER WOMAN 1

Come.

Nia looks at Mary.

Mary gives her a small reassuring smile.

Nia goes.

Simon follows, looking back once.

THE SAME TOWN — DIVIDED

The ensemble reorganizes without becoming a cartoon of good people and bad people.

Near Mary and Joseph: Shira, Adina, Dafna, Talia, Caleb, Malachi, and Ezra.

At a distance: skeptical villagers, whisperers, people who simply do not know what to think.

Levi remains between the two groups.

Nobody wins the argument.

Nazareth does not apologize.

The gossip rhythm begins to peak.

VILLAGER 1

Joseph knows—

VILLAGER 2

Before the wedding—

VILLAGER 3

An angel—

VILLAGER 1

A child—

VILLAGER 2

God—

VILLAGER 3

Can you believe—

VILLAGER 2

Everybody knows—

BOOM.

A Roman drum cuts through the marketplace.

Everything stops.

BOOM.

A trumpet or unmistakable imperial sound.

Rome does not care about Nazareth's scandal.

ROME ENTERS

The Roman Announcer enters as though his arrival is unquestionably the most important event of the day.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

People of Nazareth!

A few villagers are still murmuring.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

People.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

Of.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

Nazareth.

The village quiets.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

Thank you.

He unrolls the decree.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

By decree of Caesar Augustus—

A villager groans.

The Announcer stops and looks directly at them.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

Your enthusiasm is noted.

CALEB

We haven't even heard it yet.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

And still you've disappointed Rome.

A few villagers react.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

A census shall be taken. Every household is to be registered according to family line and ancestral city.

Immediate murmuring.

TALIA

We have to travel?

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

If your ancestral city is elsewhere, yes.

LEVI

Who pays for the journey?

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

Excellent question.

Beat.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

You do.

The village groans.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

You will present yourself, your household, and the required family information in the appropriate city.

VILLAGER

When?

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

Immediately.

CALEB

Immediately?

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

It is a wonderful word.

Beat.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

It means now.

The marketplace explodes into practical anxiety: counting, packing, questions, arguments.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

Govern yourselves accordingly.

He begins to roll the decree.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER

Thank yooou.

He exits as the Roman drum resumes.

BETHLEHEM

The marketplace is now moving for an entirely different reason.

Mary looks at Joseph.

He is doing the calculation before she asks.

MARY

Joseph?

Beat.

JOSEPH

Bethlehem.

Mary knows what that means: distance, travel, timing.

MARY

When do we leave?

Joseph looks at her.

His first instinct is to protect her.

JOSEPH

Mary—

MARY

When?

He sees that she is not asking whether she is going.

She has already decided that.

Joseph exhales.

JOSEPH

As soon as we can.

Mary nods.

Their hands find each other again.

Around them, Nazareth prepares to move.

END SCENE 9